CONNECT DAILY

Tuesday 20 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- A genuinely quiet 48 hours nationally - no new DfE, Ofsted or safeguarding announcements since the weekend.
- Locally, Sheffield's finance and performance committee met yesterday to decide on £602k of funding for SEND-places expansions at Firth Park and Parkwood academies - no outcome had surfaced publicly by this morning.

→ **For your school:** *Worth checking with the council or Lift Schools if either is a feeder or partner.*

- Reminder: Sheffield schools break for autumn half term from Monday (26-30 October).

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

27 Oct 2026 — South Yorkshire Mayoral Combined Authority Board meets.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Firth Park and Parkwood expansion goes to committee.** Sheffield's finance and performance committee met yesterday to approve passing £602,000 of government funding to Lift Schools, part of a £701,312 scheme giving Firth Park Academy three SEND rooms and 30 extra Year 7 places (240 to 270), bundled with a temporary expansion at Parkwood Academy. Both respond to a projected Year 7 places shortfall in 2027/28-2028/29. The committee's decision hadn't been reported publicly as of this morning. (The Star)

→ **For your school:** *Worth a line to SLT if either school is a feeder or partner - check back for the outcome.*

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

29.8%

Share of pupils in state-funded schools recorded as disadvantaged at the end of Key Stage 4 in 2025/26, up from 28.2% the year before - DfE attributes most of the rise to Universal Credit transitional protections. The provisional disadvantage attainment gap index narrowed slightly, to 3.82 from 3.92.

DfE, Key Stage 4 performance 2025/26 (published 15 Oct, provisional)

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.